Open Knowledge for a Sustainable Future: Research, Ethics, and Wikipedia

Week 8 — Peer review: doing it

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Roadmap

1. Peer Review & Revision in Practice

From theory to practice

- Peer review, reproducibility and citation ethics all protect the same thing: whether readers can trust the work
- Today we practise this on a smaller scale:
  - Read your partner's paper carefully
  - Give specific, constructive, respectful feedback
  - Reviewing their paper also teaches you about your own writing

Why revision matters (again)

- Good writing is rewriting: clarity, structure and claims improve with feedback
- Revision is not cosmetic editing; it is rethinking your argument and evidence
- Peer review shows you what your reader understood
- Goal today: a short list of changes you can make before the final submission

What peer review is (and isn't)

- A reader's report on clarity, evidence, logic and structure
- Specific, constructive and respectful; about the writing, not the writer
- Not copyediting every comma, and not a hunt for mistakes

$\Rightarrow$ Prioritise the few changes with the biggest impact

How to give useful feedback

- Specific: point to a sentence or paragraph and say what is unclear and why
- Diagnostic: name the problem (claim lacks evidence; paragraph lacks a topic sentence)
- Useful: propose a next step (add a source; move a paragraph; define a term)
- Balanced: one or two strengths, one or two improvements that matter most
- Praise what works; suggest specific improvements
- Think of yourself as a temporary editor, helping the author do what they set out to do

How to respond to reviews

- Read carefully: work out what the reviewer is asking, not what you fear they mean
- Respond to everything, even briefly (“We have revised X as suggested”, “We disagree because Y”)
- Be specific: quote the comment, then say what you changed (with page or line numbers)
- Don’t be defensive: assume good intent; reviewers are trying to improve your work
- If you disagree, say why, with evidence: editors respect a reasoned reply
- Thank your reviewers: they volunteered their time

Reviewer comment decoder

What reviewers write	What they often mean
“The motivation is unclear”	Your introduction doesn’t explain why anyone should care
“This needs more context”	You assumed background knowledge I don’t have
“The contribution is incremental”	I don’t see what’s new here
“Consider reorganising”	I got lost; the structure doesn’t work
“Minor revisions needed”	Fix these specific things and you’re done
“Major revisions needed”	Good potential, but significant work required
“This is interesting but…”	Brace yourself
“The authors may wish to consider…”	You really should do this

Today's workflow (40 min)

1. Swap drafts and read silently (8–10 min)
2. Complete the peer review form (10–15 min)
3. Discuss feedback with your partner (5–10 min)
4. Each writer drafts a revision plan (5 min): the top three changes

Name your review: this is non-blind, collegial feedback

Peer review form (1/2)

1) Content & Argument

- What is the main thesis / research question?
- Is the argument clear and sustained throughout?
- What claims need more evidence or better support?

2) Structure & Clarity

- Are abstract, introduction, body, conclusion present and effective?
- Does the paper flow logically? Are paragraphs coherent?

Peer review form (2/2)

3) Use of Sources

- At least 5 reliable sources?
- Are sources integrated and evaluated (not just dropped in)?
- Are citations/references consistent (APA 7)?

4) Language & Style

- Tone appropriate for an academic audience?
- Any recurring grammar/style issues affecting clarity?

5) Suggestions for Improvement

- Strongest part of the paper:
- One concrete change before final submission:

6) Overall Assessment: Perfect / Minor Revision / Major Revision / Reject

Revision memo

About one page per review, due with the revised draft

- **What you changed** (structure, argument, evidence, style) and why
- **How peer feedback helped** (cite specific comments)
- **What you did not change** (and why), if applicable
- **Remaining questions** or risks you want the instructor to note
- A guided tour of your revisions, for a reader who saw the first draft

Writer's pre-submission checklist (final paper)

- Thesis is specific and arguable; each section advances it
- Every claim with evidence; sources are credible and cited correctly
- Paragraphs have clear topic sentences; transitions guide the reader
- Figures/tables (if any) are labelled and discussed in text
- Title, abstract, and conclusion match the actual contribution

Acknowledgements

- I have had over 200 papers reviewed (thanks reviewers!)
- I have peer reviewed over 2,000 conference papers, 100 journal papers, 10 PhDs, 2 Habilitations, and many grants
- **GPT-4o** in ChatGPT (OpenAI, 2025) was used to format the references, and generate a first draft of the slides
- **Claude Opus 5** (Anthropic, 2026) was used to check the slides: to resolve every DOI against Crossref, fetch every URL, and compare each quotation with its original. The prompt was of the form

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  Verify every claim, DOI, URL and quotation against a real source. Where you cannot
  verify something, say so rather than guessing --- never invent a reference.
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  Each correction names the source it was checked against. Responsibility for what remains is mine.

References I

Anthropic. (2026). *Claude Opus 5 (Sep 20, 2026 version)* (Large language model). Retrieved September 20, 2026, from https://claude.ai/

OpenAI. (2025). *ChatGPT (Mar 14, 2025 version)* (Large language model). Retrieved October 14, 2025, from https://chat.openai.com/